

Reassessing Modality in French-based Creoles: The Case of Deontic and Epistemic Modals.

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Modal verbs are widely used in recent theories of finiteness to examine their complement structure and size. Cross-linguistically, modals can express epistemic or deontic meanings, which correlate with different syntactic behaviors, such as (dis)allowing tense/perfective markers (Coates, 1995; Bybee and Fleischman, 1995; Auwera and Plungian, 1998; Palmer and Anderson 2001). For example, Hu and Chen (2020) show, in Norwegian or Mandarin Chinese, that modals with past complements are only interpreted as epistemic. This behavior is supported by Adger's (2007) and Wurmbrand's (2014) claims that epistemic modals select raising complement, which are CP truncated and host tense, whereas deontic modals select exhaustive control complements, which are TP-truncated and unable to host tense.

In Martinican Creole (MC) and Haitian Creole (HC), it is argued that the position of the anterior marker (*té/te*) or negation (*pa*) relative to the modal determines its interpretation (Syea 2017; DeGraff 1992). For instance, in MC/HC, pre-posed markers yield deontic readings, e.g., *Jan té/te dwet/dwe manjé/manje* (Deontic: John was forced to eat) whereas post-posed markers yield epistemic readings, e.g., *Jan dwet/dwe té/te manjé/manje* (Epistemic: It is possible that John ate). While the behaviors described in these grammars for the anterior marker pre-/post-position align with what we observe in other languages, I show that the behavior of negation with modals differs from that of the anterior marker, contrary to previous grammars, therefore necessitating a separate analysis of these variables.

Using corpus data and acceptability judgments, I argue that more recent theories of finiteness can better explain the patterns attested in both Creoles, contrary to traditional descriptions. I find that MC/HC modals *dwet/dwe* and *pé/ka* in my dataset align with grammatical descriptions when paired with the anterior marker. However, I show that both epistemic and deontic interpretations are possible with pre- and post-position of *pa* and that this warrants a description of negation in terms of scope relations instead, i.e. sentential negation (SN) vs. vP negation (vPN). Furthermore, I find that, with MC deontic *pé*, negation can have sentential scope even when post-posed, e.g., *Jan pé pa manjé* (SN: John is unable to eat / vPN: John is able to not eat) and that it is more acceptable than pre-posed negation, e.g., *Jan pa pé manjé*. This behavior is unattested in previous accounts of this modal. In this work, I propose to describe modals in HC and MC as selecting control and raising complements, similarly to other (isolating) languages like Mandarin Chinese, and I explore a verb movement hypothesis. I show that in applying the more recent theories of finiteness to Creoles, we are more equipped to handle the wide range of characteristics of modality and explain the differences between the grammars and my corpus data/acceptability judgments. This research highlights the need to revisit the understanding of modality in Creole languages and their role in syntactic theory. It further demonstrates the importance of including Creoles in discussions on finiteness, challenging the notion that their isolating properties render such categories irrelevant.

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